Fortunée, and one hundred and four of the *Ceres*, were at work on Cumberland Fort; nineteen of them as masons, six as carpenters, and the rest as labourers. Most of these were unloading the ships, and carrying stones to different parts of the new works. They dine on shore at twelve o'clock. Their bread and beer were good, but they complained sadly of the meat, and indeed not without cause; for the beef was very lean, full of bones, and not half the allowance, viz. one pound to each man before it is dressed.

"All who are employed in the public works on shore have, each day they work, one pint of small beer, the king's allowance. Most of them had a ring on one leg, and the other ring fastened to their waistband.[1]

"Both the ships were clean, particularly the *Ceres*. The *Fortunée* had few sick in that part called the hospital; but the *Ceres* had many more sick than the hospital part could contain. Several had the gaol-fever, and a few, petechiæ. Six out of ten that went from Bedford were dead, and two of the others were very sickly and dispirited.[2] The convicts lie two on a straw bed, with one blanket; and after one is taken ill, his companion soon sickens. Some few have hammocks, which in every view are better, and I wish they were in general use, except in the hospital ships. The *Ceres* being an old receiving ship, may be one cause of its being contaminated with infection; and most of the convicts here are from the country. There is not however, in general, that attention to cleanliness in the clothes, linen, and persons of the prisoners in the hulks which is necessary to preserve their health: for though some were decently clothed in their own clothes, others were in rags; many without shirts. All should be clothed in a sailor's uniform, of jacket, trousers, etc., and I could wish that the whole of Saturday were appropriated to cleanliness, viz. bathing, washing and mending their clothes, shaving, cleaning themselves and every part of the

[1] "It is asserted by some persons, and Government are made to believe it, that these convicts do more work than common day-labourers. But, from the frequent observation of them, I am convinced the contrary is the truth; and indeed, how could it be expected that men who labour involuntarily, with scanty diet, and small encouragement, should exert themselves with as much spirit as those who have the pleasing idea of a wife and children to share in their gains?

[2] "The gaoler at Reading told me, 12 July, 1788, that of the eleven convicts whom he carried on board the hulks, 1 April, 1787, all were dead but three. I have observed, that convicts from the country often pine away and die without any apparent sign of illness; and that of equal numbers, from the country, and from Newgate, three or four of the former die for one of the latter.

ships, and beating and airing their bedding. Thus endeavouring to introduce habits of cleanliness is an object of great importance; as many officers have observed, "that the most cleanly men are always the most decent and honest, and the most slovenly and dirty are the most vicious and irregular." On other days, none who are able should be excused from work. There were in the *Fortunée* one hundred excused from work, though the ship was healthy.

"It would be better if there were a diet table painted and hung up in every hulk, for the inspection of the convicts; and if they were permitted to choose two of their number to see that justice is done to them, as in the ninth article of the rules for the prisoners of war, which I formerly published; and proper scales, weights and measures ought to be kept for their use. There should also be a table of rules and orders, similar to that for prisoners of war, with a strict prohibition against profaneness, which, I am sorry to say, is particularly necessary for the guards of these convicts. A gentleman of reputation should be appointed as commissary, to whom the prisoners, in case of cruelty or injustice, might immediately appeal; and who also should see that the money allowed by Government, at the end of their term, be given them. See Act sixteenth George III, cap. 43 and Act twenty-fourth George III, cap. 12, sect. 6. By this Act, and another of the same year, cap. 56, sect. 9, it is declared: "That all the time during which any offender, shall have continued in gaol under sentence of transportation, or being removed under the provisions aforesaid, shall continue confined by virtue of this Act, shall be taken and reckoned in discharge, or part discharge, or satisfaction of the term of his transportation." Some of the convicts were sentenced for life, others for fourteen, seven, five, or three years: among these were boys; and all associating together without distinction. Is it not contrary to justice and humanity to send convicts who are not sentenced for life, to a settlement so remote that there is no probability of their return; and a still greater hardship to those who are sent after they have been four or five years and upwards in confinement, as some were in the last fleet to Botany Bay?

"I think it will be admitted that the mode of confinement and labour in the hulks is too severe for the far greater number of those who are confined in them. At the same time, there is no proportion of punishment to the several offences, and consequently, no distinction of guilt; which many wise legislators have long lamented as an evil which wants to be remedied.